

6.3b

The style of business reports

Worksheet

D Look at these sentences that come from a report on investment advice. What do you think of the writing style?

- 1 The US stock market will rise next year.
- 2 Property is a very cyclical market.
- 3 Analysts believe that the telecomms sector has better potential than the rest of the market.
- 4 Inflation is less dangerous now than in the 1970s.
- 5 Bonds are a safer investment than shares. Shares give a better return in the long term.
- 6 Gold prices will not go any lower.
- 7 Young people invest for capital growth and old people invest for income, but this is not always true.
- 8 The best option is to spread your money over several forms of investment.

Rewrite the eight sentences using the techniques in the table. These techniques will help you to create a balanced style that shows you have considered the points carefully.

Giving both sides of an argument

In general ... , however ...
On the whole ... , but ...

Making a statement less general

Many / Some
usually / typically / often

Making a statement less certain

It is possible / probable that ...
It seems / appears that ...
... tends to be ...
... is likely to / is expected to / will probably / might ...
... probably will not / is not expected to / is unlikely to ...

Making a comparison more/less strong

++ substantially / considerably / much slower growth
+ a significantly / relatively more risky investment
- a marginally / slightly more expensive option

Concluding

On balance, ...
Taking everything into consideration, ...

E Choose one of the topics below and write a short report. Use techniques from sections A and D to keep your style impersonal and balanced.

- 1 Write a short report describing the economic and political outlook for your country over the next year.
- 2 Rewrite this short report about the future of the Internet. You can change the original and introduce your own ideas.

The Internet is the most important technological advance since the wheel. Soon you will never have to leave home. Cinemas will disappear as people download movies on demand, shops will disappear as people walk through virtual supermarkets and order goods with a click of the mouse. In the service sector everyone will work from home and videoconferencing will replace meetings. People will meet future husbands and wives through on-line chat areas that select people with similar interests. Most people will live inside Information Villages with green spaces and high walls. The remainder will live outside the walls where armed guards will feed them soup and give them blankets during the winter.